

Fuelling a revolution

Behind India's para sport success lies a **growing network** of corporate sponsorships.

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Anukool Bharadwaj, currently heading the para sports wing at Olympic Gold Quest (OGQ), vividly remembers the 2019 World Para Athletics Championships in Dubai. And no, it isn't just because of the twin world-record throws by javelin superstars Sandeep Chaudhary (F44) and Sumit Antil (F64) on November 8.

High jumper Nishad Kumar (T47), now a double Paralympic silver medallist, was an unheralded figure back then. He had made the cut for the showpiece event in the City of Gold, but didn't meet the set criteria for the Paralympic Committee of India (PCI) to cover the expenses of his trip. Unable to afford the cost of participation himself, Nishad knocked on the doors of OGQ, who were quick to act.

"OGQ funded his entire trip. If that hadn't happened, an important moment in Nishad's career wouldn't have come through," says a proud Anukool.

Nishad repaid the favour on November 13 by not only bagging a bronze medal and recording his personal best (2.00m) but also securing a berth at the Tokyo Paralympics.

As clichéd as it may sound, the rest, as they say, is history. He went on to win silver in the Japanese

capital, gold at the Hangzhou Para Asian Games in 2022, before finishing second once again at the 2024 Summer Para Games. He also won back-to-back silver medals at the World Championships in 2023 and 2024. OGQ is presently helping Nishad train in the US with renowned track-and-field coach Jeremy Fischer.

To be sure, Nandan Kamath, managing trustee at the GoSports Foundation, could relate to Anukool when Sumit recently tested his limits at an able-bodied meet in Geneva. "That's an incredible transition within a 10-year period, isn't it? From being unsupported in 2015 to showing up at Atleticageneve — EAP (a bronze-tier meet on the World Athletics calendar) in 2025... And that itself tells you how far we have come," Kamath tells *Sportstar*.

Sumit, the current F64 world-record holder, may have hurled the javelin only 68.58m, a far cry from his best of 73.29m, but the fact that he chose to break down the proverbial barrier and compete in the open category is a feat that will

be talked about for years to come.

OGQ, GoSports, and IndianOil have countless such anecdotes to share, if someone's listening.

The para-athlete support system works in very different ways across these three organisations. OGQ and GoSports, both non-profit ventures, thrive on CSR partnerships and donations. IndianOil, on the other hand, is a Public Sector Undertaking (PSU) that doles out an exclusive scholarship scheme called *Divyashakti* for para-athletes.

"*Divyashakti* offers 100 scholarships to para-athletes. Out of that, 50 per cent are for women. And that's a first. It includes a stipend of ₹15,000-30,000 per month and reimbursement of tournament and kit expenses. Additionally, a one-time allowance of ₹60,000 is handed out per year," says Manjusha Kanwar, DGM-Sports Coordination at IndianOil.

IndianOil, which had signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with the Paralympic Committee of India (PCI) to support differently-abled athletes ahead of

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